DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Say Shema So Many Times a Day?

Daat Tevunot §35-36

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §35-36 (with a review of §1-34) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 24 October 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Starting the winter term: the story so far

The first class after the Sukkot break opened with a review, so that the group would know where the next few months are heading. - Daat Tevunot is the next step after Derech Hashem, written as a dialogue. The Neshamah believes, but what it knows intellectually has not settled in the heart: "veyadata hayom vahashevota el levavekha," know it, and bring it down to your heart. - Its main difficulties are theodicy (why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper), Mashiah, tehiyat hametim and how involved God is in the world. - The Sekhel answers that there is a long journey ahead. Like the Rambam, the Ramhal does things in order; he will not give the answer "on one foot." First: why are we in this world? - We are here to complete ourselves. God is good and wants to give the ultimate good, which is Himself. He cannot make other gods, so the best He can do is let us connect to Him. That is our definition of olam haba, very different from other religions' idea of paradise. He did not create us as finished angels, but as incomplete beings with a choice between body and soul, so that we achieve the good ourselves rather than receive it as a gift. - He does this by creating good and bad in the world, and we choose good.

Why only unity can be known

The principle the Ramhal now develops is yihud Hashem. Any other attribute, such as the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy, cannot be fully grasped. A human being's compassion can be framed: he is compassionate in this way or that. God's compassion is all-encompassing and limitless, so any border we give it makes no sense. That is why the Rambam says that "Rahum veHanun" means only that God comes across to us as merciful, and that we should learn to be merciful too. The one trait we can fully ascertain is unity, because it is a negative: to say He is one is to block out everything else.

The Rabbi recalled his Shabbat sermon: the Ramhal's whole philosophy is that the entire universe is about yihud Hashem. He hoped this had already changed how the group approached Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur: not "me, me, give me this," the way we think of the days when young, but focusing on the majesty of God, in which we are insignificant.

"Surely one is simple" (§35-36)

The Neshamah asks: why go into this at length? Unity means God is one and there are not two. Simple.

The Sekhel answers in §36: yes, that is the general idea, but it must be investigated further. Moshe told the people, "attah horeita ladaat," you have been shown that Hashem is God, "ein od milvado," there is nothing else. The Rabbis explain: not even witchcraft. Then come the lines the Rabbi asked the group to underline: - It is not enough to recognise that there is one existing entity we call God and nothing else. That is the basic level. - We must understand that there is absolutely no authority or ruler besides Him, no leader, and no creature or entity in the entire universe with any power or control besides Him. - Nothing can prevent Him or hold back His will.

That is what is meant by His unity being one and His authority being singular. The Ramhal cites Haazinu: "I put to death and I give life, I strike and I heal, and none can deliver from My hand," and Iyov: He is one, and who can answer Him?

Why repeat it four times a day?

If yihud Hashem only meant "one God, not two," why would we say Shema Yisrael so many times: in the korbanot, in Shaharit, in Arvit, before sleep, and at the moment of death? Because it is very hard to believe. The world we see contradicts it. We see prime ministers, presidents, powerful and wealthy people, all apparently in control.

A person who not only believes but feels this, and lets it govern every decision, finds it very hard to sin. The Rabbi described two ways of doing teshuvah. One is practical: work on your character trait by trait. The other, far easier, addresses the underlying issue. If we truly lived knowing that nothing in the world goes against Hashem's will, we would not be tempted to lie or steal, we would not take revenge when upset, we would not speak lashon hara. When something enticing appears, you recognise that it too comes from Hashem. "It's easy once you know it. More, once you actually live your life like that." That is why Yom Kippur ends with "Hashem hu haElokim."

If God is in control, why do bad things happen?

A participant asked about prayer and how it fits with there being only one power. The Rabbi answered with a question of his own. God loves every human being, Jew and non-Jew, and wants the best for us. Yet there are negative consequences in the Torah for wrongdoing. Does God want them to happen? A participant said that some punishment is educational. The Rabbi accepted that, but asked about consequences that are not educational. He added that he does not like the word "punishment" at all, since there is no such concept; "negative consequences" is better.

The answer, from Derech Hashem: God created a system, a judicial system of consequences, and, "kivyakhol," as it were, His hands are tied behind His back. If you walk into the road with your eyes closed, a car will hit you. "How much I love you, I don't want that to happen to you, but I've created a system and I'm bound to it." That is hanhagat hamishpat, the way the world

runs most of the time. Within that system there are the Satan and the other forces, and what we pray for operates within the system.

But He remains in control, because at certain times, including certain times of the year, there is hanhagat hayihud, an override button. The Rabbi compared it to playing a game with his children: while playing, he limits himself, but when the game ends, he is in charge again.

Coming next: five mistaken philosophies

The Ramhal will now go through five philosophies that yihud Hashem demolishes. Some were held by ancient idol worshippers such as the Egyptians, some by ordinary people who simply do not think much, some by non-Jews, and some by Jewish people who deliberately went astray. The next class would be on Wednesday, and from the following week, with the clocks changing, the shiurim return to Monday and Thursday after Minhah and Arvit.

Summary

- The book so far: we are here to earn closeness to God, the ultimate good, by choosing good over bad.
- Of all God's attributes only unity can be fully known, because it is a negation; the whole universe, for the Ramhal, is about yihud Hashem.
- Unity means far more than "one God, not two": there is no other ruler, power or director anywhere, and nothing can block His will.
- We repeat Shema constantly because the world seems to show other powers; living with this makes teshuvah far easier.
- God binds Himself to a system of consequences (hanhagat hamishpat) but can override it (hanhagat hayihud).

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